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CLEAN TECH

Green race: Will the world of fashion make the cut?

Is it possible to make the highly polluting garment industry sustainable and eco-friendly, asks Preeti Mehra

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(Clockwise from left) Skirt and top made of wheat straw, by Fortum; IBA Crafts follows a 'just in time garments manufacturing' tech process so new designs can be created every day without stocking any inventory

It is hard to imagine that the trendy jeans or the designer dress you picked up from your neighbourhood retail outlet could be contributing to global warming and degradation. But experts are veering around to the view that the growth of fast fashion in recent times, which enables garment manufacturers to offer consumers fresh designs within weeks of launching one line, and that too at affordable prices, is a serious threat to the environment.



True the garment industry has grown in the process, and fashion democratised, but the demand for cotton, polyester and chemical dyes has also seen a remarkable rise to feed this growth. It has consequently led to an upping of the carbon footprint of the industry, increased water consumption, pollution of rivers and oceans, as well as a rapid turnover of old clothes ending up at landfills.

But till two years ago, very few within the industry were ready to see the writing on the wall and the cost of the fashion explosion. In this context, 2018 will go down as a landmark year when realisation finally dawned that something needed to be done urgently to contain the damage caused by high fashion and fast fashion.

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